

Translation Studies

6. The analysis of translation as text

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Source: Károly, 2002



Introduction

- Aim of translation: translation of the meaning conveyed in texts as a whole (Neubert & Shreve, 1992)
- T theory and practice: shift from concern with equivalence to the need for adaptation to the target situation and purpose → focus on communicative functions and text type (Trosborg, 1997)
- Discourse analysts: writers intend to meet the needs of an implied "ideal reader" → translators translate to meet the needs of their readers in the target language (Ruuskanen, 1995)



The analysis of translation:

**methodological + theoretical
considerations**



Task of translator = manifold

→ several intervening factors

Original author	Translator	Parallel texts
Source text	Target text	
Original audience	Target audience	
Original context	Target context	



Relevant areas of study in translation:

- Pragmatic aspects (original audience vs. target audience, e.g., modern English-speaking one)
- Context (original vs. target): writer intention, reader expectation, medium, time/place of reception
- Source- and target-text analysis (intercultural, interlingual aspects, personal preferences of translators)
- Translation problems
- Translation strategies



Objects of study:

Textual aspects ("product"):

- comparison between ST and TT
- translated vs. original language

Cognitive aspects ("process"):

- cognitive processing
- translation competence, etc.



Three basic models in translation research (Chesterman, 2000):

(1) **comparative** model:

TT vs. ST;

TT vs. parallel (untranslated) T

→ contrastive studies

(allow statements about L-pair translation rules, L-system contrasts, translation product universals)



Basic models in T research cont.

(2) **process** model:

maps different phases of the translation process over time → communication and protocol approaches

(allow statements about typical translation behavior, temporal distribution of different translation tasks, decision-making, translation process universals)



Basic models in T research cont.

(3) **causal** model: translations

- as caused by antecedent conditions, or
- as causing effects on readers and cultures ("Why...?")

→ contains the other two models and can accommodate all four types of hypotheses interpretive, descriptive, explanatory, predictive



**The analysis of written
discourse = theoretical
background for the analysis
of translation as text**



Figure 1: The components of the science of text following de Beaugrande (1980)

<i>cohesion</i> <i>coherence</i>	→ text-oriented	TEXT
<i>intentionality</i> <i>acceptability</i>	→ psychologically-oriented	MIND
<i>situationality</i> <i>intertextuality</i>	→ socially-oriented	SOCIETY



Figure 2: Orientations of written text analysis influencing recent research (Károly, 1998)

MIND
Psychological/
cognitive
approaches

TEXT
Language-specific
approaches



Kintsch&vanDijk
(1978)

Mann&Thompson
(1986, 1988)

Swales
(1990)

Hasan
(1984)

Halliday&Hasan
(1976)



macrostructure
proposition
analysis



Rhetorical
structure
Relational
propositions



Genre
analysis



Cohesive
harmony



Cohesive devices

Recent advances in the study of the cognitive, textual and social aspects of translation



(1) Advances in the study of cognitive aspects:

■ **Beeby** (2000): topic: translation competence and its acquisition (process)

RQ: design experimental research tool to investigate empirically sub-competences

Focus: measuring instrument, subjects and tasks of the experiments

■ **Gutt** (2000): topic: communication problems in T (causal)

RQ: how optimal relevance can be used to predict the communicability of the message to be translated, how communication problems can be predicted and avoided

Focus: Sperber and Wilson's (1986) relevance theory



Cogn. aspects cont.

■ **Tirkkonen-Condit** (1985): topic: (argumentative) text structure and translation

RQ: produce method for structural description of text and show that the knowledge of the structure of text has consequences for its interpretation

Data: argumentative texts (most difficult to translate - comprehension problems)

Focus: among others, van Dijk's macrostructure and superstructure model

■ **Nord** (1997): topic: functional analysis of translation problems

RQ: find an alternative to the already existing equivalence models which bare no relevance to situation, culture, and non-equivalent texts (e.g., summaries)

Focus: functionality plus loyalty model, which lies on two pillars: (1) communication-oriented concept of textuality and (2) target-oriented concept of translation.



(2) Recent advances in the study of textual (and social) aspects:

-  **(2a) Study of text-surface elements and cohesion**
-  **(2b) Genre studies (social aspects)**



(2a) Study of text-surface elements and cohesion

- **Rogers** (1997): topic: synonymy and equivalence
RQ: examine how synonymic variation can be compared crosslinguistically with a view to identifying whether any regular patterns of equivalence may be established
Data: German and English journal articles in genetic engineering
Focus: influencing factors of the choice of synonyms and equivalents, where such variation is not obviously motivated by pragmatic or denotational factors but rather by immediate linguistic content
- **Polo** (1995): topic: cohesion in the Ts of popular science texts from English into Spanish
RQ: whether or not there is a shift in the cohesion and coherence of these texts when translated from English into Spanish
Data: two articles from the *Scientific American* and their corresponding Spanish versions
Focus: reference, lexical cohesion, conjunction, and theme (Halliday and Hasan's work)



(2a) cont.

■ **Svindland** (1995): topic: coordination (*and*, *or*) in Norwegian and English

RQ: examine whether the distribution of coordination differs in the two Ls

Data: originals and Ts in the two Ls (fictional literature)

Focus: show that coordination is not a L universal (identical what and how it expresses it in all Ls)

■ **Kenny** (2000): topic: lexical creativity and conventionality (what is not lexically routine)

RQ: whether linguistic normalization is a feature of T

Data: parallel corpus of literary texts in German and their English Ts

Focus: on word forms that occur only once, writer-specific forms

■ **Klaudy & Károly** (2000): topic: text-organizing function of Lic features (lexical repetition)

RQ: how the use of lexical repetition (as a cohesive device) may predict translation quality (differing discourse strategies)

Data: English newspaper article and its Hungarian translations by professionals and novices

Focus: how bonds created by repetition affect T quality



(2b) Genre studies

 **Bathia** (1997): topic: a genre-based approach to translation

RQ: find a way to maintain generic identity of the TT

Data: legal genres

Focus: four areas of competence added to linguistic competence:

- (a) understanding of the two codes
- (b) acquisition of genre knowledge
- (c) sensitivity to cognitive structures
- (d) exploitation of generic knowledge

 **Trosborg** (1997): topic: text typology and communicative function

RQ: identify classificatory categories to classify texts, because lack of relevant knowledge of genre, communicative functions, text types and culture may result in distorted Ts

Focus: Swales's (1990) defining criterion of communicative purpose, Halliday's functional approach to language (field-tenor-mode)



(2b) cont.

■ **Schäffner** (1997): topic: strategies of translating political texts

RQ: illustrate that the various functions that influence the TT (addressees, situation, function of TT in TL community, text type) are not of equal relevance, and that it is above all the functions of the ST and the TT in their respective cultures that determine translation strategies

Focus: translation problems (caused by insufficient linguistic competence or insufficient analysis of ST)

■ **Pilegaard** (1997): topic: translation of medical research articles

RQ: contrastive analysis of problems, trustworthiness, thought-styles, culture-specific differences of the translations of medical RAs

Data: Danish and English

Focus: equivalence at word level (propositional meaning, lexical barrier, register mismatch, inflexional anglicisation of Greek and Latin roots, culture-specific concepts, Latin and Greek loanwords, synonyms) and pragmatic equivalence (rhetorical style, styles of argumentation, anaphoric/cataphoric patterns)



Problems in research in the field

- the variety and distinct nature of text types / genres (letters, essays, research articles, etc.)
- inconsistency in the quantity and the quality of data submitted to analysis (merely sentences or paragraphs, particular paragraphs of a larger text, or even whole chapters of scientific books)
- the complex structure of texts constituted by the various levels of language:
 - intrasentential
 - intersentential
 - discourse



Problems cont.

- the theoretical potential of text Lcs is not exploited enough
- great number of descriptive, case studies
- unreliable analyses caused by the lack of precise definitions for the categories examined by the taxonomies
- the interdisciplinary approach of analysis required by the presence of the numerous factors that interact
- basis of comparison is unfounded (ST, TT, PT)
- still few empirical studies
- methodologically weak research designs
- lack of applicability of results in translator training

